

Calcium and Heart Disease

One test, Doctors do to understand a person's risk of heart disease is a coronary artery calcium scan which is a special type of CT scan. It measures the amount of calcium in the wall of the coronary arteries and generate a calcium score. The higher the score the greater the risk Heart attack. If your Calcium score is zero, your risk of heart attack.

Higher the score, higher the risk of heart attack Calcium makes up just a small part of the harmful buildup known as Plaque which narrows the coronary arteries. Plaques also contain cholesterol, inflammatory cells, and scar tissue. On the CT scan, the cholesterol is not visible, but the calcium is easily seen.

Because there is a close correlation between the amount of calcium and amount of plaque, calcium score is a good indicator of plaque inside the arteries There is always a question if the calcium in the diet or from the supplements you take affect your calcium score, according to a study published in one of the major cardiac journals, which was a 20 year study people 45 to 64 years of age, people who consumed the highest amount of calcium from their diet had less calcium in their coronary arteries Compared to people who consume the lowest amount of calcium.

Result is consistent with other well done research showing that dietary calcium is beneficial, calcium helps to lower blood pressure, possibly by improving the function of the lining of the blood vessels. It's one reason DASH diet, which stands for dietary approach to hypertension, includes two servings of low-fat calcium, rich dairy foods per day.

So it is better to get enough calcium from the diet. In the United States, 3/4 of the dietary calcium comes from dairy, products and foods featuring dairy. People who follow vegan diet, which excludes dairy and other animal based foods, may need to make sure that they get enough calcium. Many brands of almond milk, oat milk, or other plant based milks are fortified with calcium.

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What about calcium supplements which are often recommended for post menopausal women to help prevent osteoporosis. Although some research suggest a link between high dose of calcium say 1000 mg daily supplement and heart disease, other research does not. Still, it is best to get your calcium from food.

Avoid supplements unless your physician recommends one and many experts advise no more than 500 mg pill per day taken with the food to improve absorption. Some of the Calcium rich foods include low fat yogurt, tofu, almond milk, oat milk, 1% milk, ricotta, greek yogurt, kale, cheese, Sardines, salmon I hope this information will help some of you.

Dr Keshava Aithal

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